

A retaliation

The sketches may have been published as a reaction to the Swadeshi movement of 1905, an economic strategy adopted by Indians seeking independence, to boost the local economy. It asked for Indians to boycott British goods and only buy products made in India. The sketches were meant to be a satirical take on the railways, if they were to be “truly Swadeshi in conception, equipment, and management”.

The cleverly drawn 53-page booklet was sold at Re ½ and depicted scenes on the fictitious Koochpurwanaypore Railway (KPR), punctuated with anglicized versions of local Hindustani phrases. Koochpurwanay was meant to convey the artist’s sentiment that Indians, by themselves, were unable to handle a complex and vast enterprise such as the railways.

Colonial chauvinism

The author wrote in his foreword to the book, “The tribe of the Koochpurwanay, as everyone knows, has its home in the heart of India, some of its better known family names are *Pichi, kal, abbi nay*, and *hazr hi*”, which are translated to mean behind (in schedule), tomorrow, not now, and present (in attendance), respectively. The sketches mocked the technological know-how and managerial skills of the natives.

The artist seemed to advance the argument that there was no hint of an understanding of modern technology in the minds of the Indian population. Instead, they seemed to gravitate towards the idea of heavy dependence on manual labour. While the Indian workforce was shown as absurdly ignorant, those in positions of power were portrayed as careless and irresponsible. The shambolic portrayal of the living conditions conveyed the idea of a society so primitive, it would turn into *Mutwalabad* – the land of the inebriated – as soon as the British left.

Representation at last?

With a positive outlook, and the clarity of hindsight, it could be argued that *Koochpurwanaypore* accidentally brought some representation to the natives in the context of the British Indian railways. Even though the book’s central focus is railways, the artist slips in, deliberately or